MEMBER GUIDES · C1

Considering Freemasonry

For men thinking about joining, and for those who have just applied. One purpose: no surprises.

For	Candidates and enquirers
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Welcome

If you are reading this, you are somewhere on a path that many thousands of men in Hertfordshire have walked before you: curious about Freemasonry, perhaps already in conversation with a member, perhaps with an application under way. Wherever you are on that path, this guide is for you.

It has one purpose: to make sure there are no surprises. We would rather you knew exactly what Freemasonry asks of you - in time, in money, and in commitment - before you decide, than discover it afterwards. A man who joins with his eyes open arrives relaxed and curious. That is how we want you to arrive.

And one thing before anything else. Whatever you decide, your priorities are your own, and ours are clear: **family first, work second, Freemasonry third - in that order, always.** Freemasonry is designed to fit into a full life, not to compete with it.

What Freemasonry Is - and Isn't

Freemasonry is one of the world's oldest social and charitable organisations. Its purpose, in a sentence: to help good men become better - through friendship, through a set of moral values acted out in ceremony, and through service to

others. Its values are Integrity, Friendship, Respect and Service. Its ceremonies, which you will experience rather than read about, are built around three simple themes: look after those less fortunate; work on yourself; and live a life worth remembering for the right reasons.

What it is not: a business-networking club. If any part of you hopes membership will bring professional advantage, we ask you to leave that expectation at the door - you will be disappointed, and quickly. Members are actively discouraged from using Freemasonry for personal gain. Men who join for the friendship stay for decades; men who join for advantage rarely stay at all.

Nor is it a secret society. Our buildings are public, our rules are published, and members are free to say they are Freemasons. The so-called secrets are ceremonial - traditional modes of recognition used inside our meetings - and the reason we don't describe the ceremonies in advance is not concealment. It is the same reason nobody tells you the end of a good film: the experience is the point.

The Journey to Membership

The path from first conversation to membership usually looks like this. Timescales vary between Lodges - months rather than weeks is normal, and that is deliberate: both you and the Lodge are making a considered decision.

Stage	What happens
Getting to know each other	You will be invited to meet members socially - a drink, a meal, perhaps a Lodge social event with partners. This matters: by the time anything formal happens, you should be among people you already know. Ask anything you like at this stage; there are no wrong questions.
The application	A member proposes you, a second supports you, and you complete a registration form. National checks are made for every candidate in England and Wales - this is normal and applies to everyone.
The interview	A relaxed, honest conversation with a small group of senior Lodge members - see the next section. Dress smartly; be yourself.
The ballot	The Lodge's members vote on your application at a Lodge meeting. Your Proposer will tell you the outcome promptly.
Your Initiation	The ceremony at which you become a Freemason - a dignified, entirely safe, and genuinely memorable evening. You will be guided at every step, and you will have a named friend beside you throughout (see 'Who Will Support You').

The Interview - What to Expect

The interview is not an examination, and nobody is trying to catch you out. The Lodge wants to understand three things: why you are interested in Freemasonry; whether you understand the commitment; and whether membership is right for you at this point in your life. Expect questions like: What drew you to Freemasonry? What do you hope to find in it? Does your family support the idea? Have you thought about the time and cost?

You should interview us too. A good Lodge will ask itself not 'Is this man right for our Lodge?' but 'Is our Lodge right for this man?' - and you should ask the same. Where does the Lodge meet, and how convenient is that for you, honestly, on a winter Tuesday? What is the age profile - will you find company you enjoy? How often does it meet? If the fit is not right, a good Lodge will say so and help you find one that is. That is not a rejection; it is the first act of care Freemasonry will show you.

The Commitment - Honestly Stated

- **Time.** A Lodge typically meets formally a handful of times a year, with a rehearsal evening (the Lodge of Instruction) between meetings, plus social events. In your early years expect roughly one to two evenings a month in Lodge season. More is available if you want it; less is manageable when life demands.
- **Money.** There is a one-off Initiation fee, an annual subscription, and the cost of dining at meetings, plus modest charitable giving - always at a level you choose and can afford. Your Proposer will give you the actual figures for the Lodge before you commit. If the numbers are not comfortable, say so; there are Lodges at a range of price points, and no one should join beyond their means.
- **Learning.** Freemasonry involves some learning by heart - short passages, at your own pace, with help. Some members grow to love this part; others keep it to a minimum. Both are fine. Nobody is ever forced to perform.
- **Family.** Talk to your partner and family before you apply. Lodges increasingly involve partners and families in social events, and a supportive home makes for a happy Mason. If your family has questions, your Proposer or mentor will gladly answer them too.

Who Will Support You

From the moment your application is under way, you are not on your own - and you never will be.

- **Your Proposer and Seconder** brought you to the Lodge and remain your sponsors throughout.
- **A Personal Mentor** - an experienced member chosen to suit you - will be assigned to you around the time of your ballot. He is your guide and friend: the person you can ask anything, at any time, without ever feeling foolish. He will prepare you for every stage before it happens, contact you the day before your Initiation, and be beside you on the night.
- **The Lodge Mentor** co-ordinates this support across the whole Lodge and makes sure it never lapses.

Before your Initiation, your mentor will make sure you know the practical things: what to wear, when to arrive, what the evening will look like in outline, and what will be asked of you. We won't describe the ceremony itself - that is a gift we won't spoil - but we promise you this: everyone in the room has been exactly where you will be standing, the ceremony is symbolic, safe and conducted with dignity, and you will be guided at every step.

Questions Men Actually Ask

The question	The honest answer
Will it help my career or business?	No - and it is not meant to. See above. Join for the friendship, the values and the journey, or not at all.
Is there anything my family should worry about?	No. Your family will know where you are, partners are welcome at social events, and there is written guidance you can share with them after each ceremony.
Do I have to be religious?	Freemasonry asks that you have a personal faith in a Supreme Being, in whatever form your own tradition holds. Men of all faiths are members, side by side. Religion (and politics) are never discussed in Lodge.
What if I can't kneel / can't read easily / have a health condition?	Tell your Proposer or mentor, in confidence, early. Ceremonies are adapted with care and dignity every week, and no condition you disclose will be met with anything but practical kindness.
What if it turns out not to be for me?	Then you may leave, without drama, and part as friends. We would rather you tried it honestly than never tried it at all.

How fast will I progress?	At your pace. There are three ceremonies (degrees) in your first year or two, and beyond that everything - office, learning, deeper involvement - is invitation, never pressure.

Finding Out More

- Talk to your Proposer, or to any Freemason you know - we like the questions.
- www.ugle.org.uk - the United Grand Lodge of England, including what Freemasonry is and does nationally.
- www.pgherts.org - Hertfordshire Freemasons: local news, events and contacts.
- www.mcf.org.uk - the Masonic Charitable Foundation, one of the largest grant-giving charities in the country, funded entirely by Freemasons and their families.

We look forward to meeting you. And if you do join us: welcome - you will never walk alone.

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